

Hungary

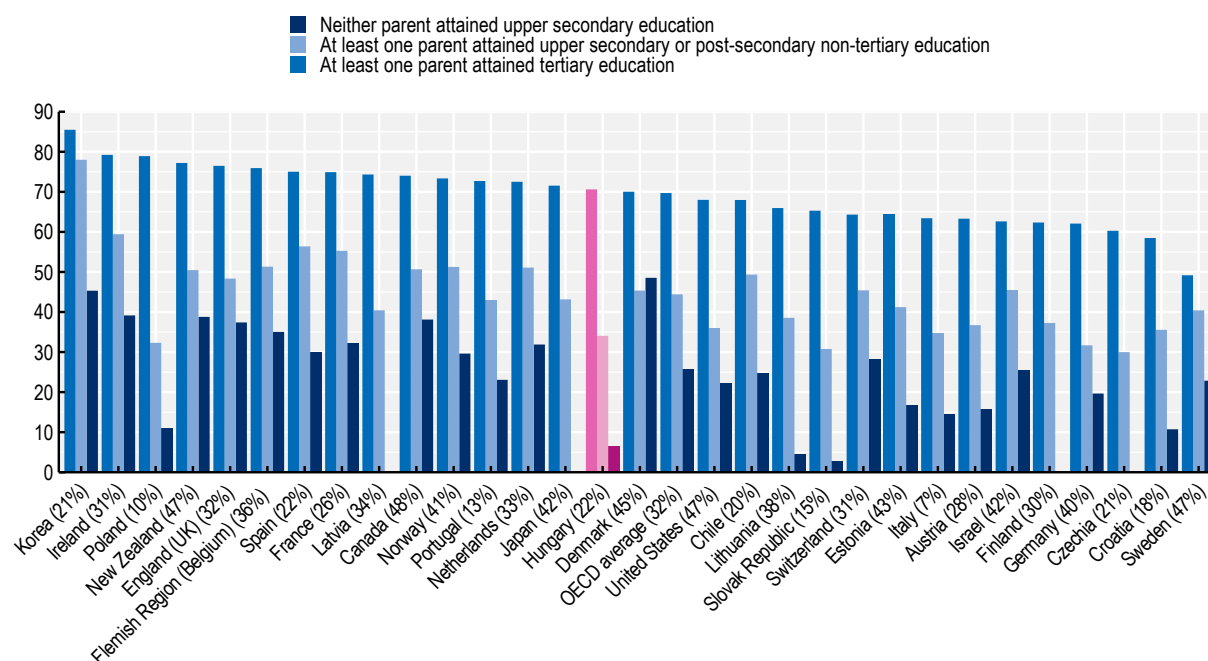
This country note provides an overview of the key characteristics of the education system in Hungary based on data from *Education at a Glance 2025*. In line with this year's thematic focus, it emphasises tertiary education while also covering other parts of the education system. The data in this note are provided for the latest available year. Readers interested in the reference years for the data should refer to the corresponding tables in *Education at a Glance 2025*.

The output of educational institutions and the impact of learning

- Educational inequalities persist across generations. In all countries with available data, young adults (25-34 year-olds) are significantly more likely to attain a tertiary qualification if their parents have also done so. In Hungary, 71% of 25-34 year-olds with at least one tertiary-educated parent have also attained a tertiary qualification, compared to only 6% among those whose parents did not complete upper secondary education. This tertiary-attainment gap of 65 percentage points is one of the largest among OECD countries gap of 44 percentage points (Figure 1).

Figure 1. Share of 25-34 year-olds with tertiary education, by parental educational attainment (2023)

Survey of Adult Skills, in per cent



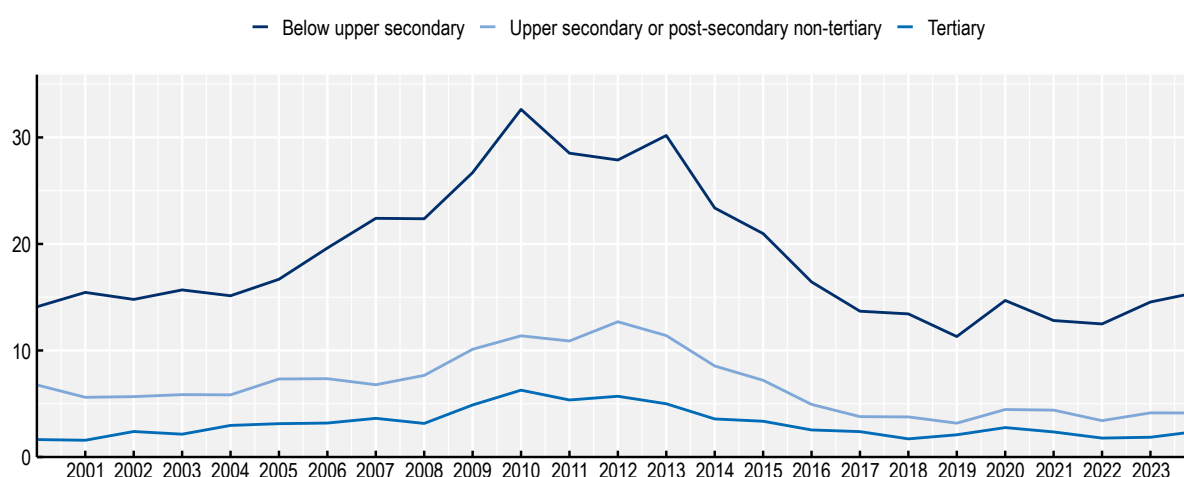
Note: The percentage in parentheses represents the share of tertiary-educated parents.

For data, see OECD (2025) *Education at a Glance 2025: OECD Indicators*, <https://doi.org/10.1787/1c0d9c79-en>, Table A1.4 (available on line).

- The share of young adults (25-34 year-olds) without upper secondary attainment continues to decline across the OECD, reaching an average of 13%. This trend also continues in Hungary, where the share fell from 13% to 12% between 2019 and 2024.
- Individuals with greater educational attainment generally face a lower risk of unemployment and earn higher wages. Completing upper secondary education is particularly important in reducing the risk of unemployment. On average across the OECD, 12.9% of economically active young adults (25-34 year-olds) without an upper secondary qualification are unemployed, compared to 6.9% of those with upper secondary or post-secondary non-tertiary attainment. Those who go on to gain a tertiary qualification see a relatively smaller further reduction in unemployment, with 4.9% of tertiary-educated young adults unemployed on average across the OECD. This pattern is similar in Hungary (albeit at a lower level): 15.5% of young adults without an upper secondary qualification are unemployed, compared to 4.1% of those with upper secondary or post-secondary non-tertiary attainment and 2.4% of those with tertiary attainment (Figure 2).

Figure 2. Trends in unemployment rates of 25-34 year-olds in Hungary, by educational attainment (2000 to 2024)

In per cent



For data, see OECD (2025) *Education at a Glance 2025: OECD Indicators*, <https://doi.org/10.1787/1c0d9c79-en>, Table A3.5.

- On average, individuals with a master's or equivalent degree have significantly higher employment rates and earnings than those with a bachelor's or equivalent degree. However, the share of young adults (25-34 year-olds) attaining a master's or equivalent qualification varies widely across OECD countries, ranging from 1% to 39% in 2024. In Hungary, 21% of 25-34 year-olds hold a master's or equivalent degree, which is above the OECD average of 16%. This represents an increase since 2019, when the share was 15%.
- The average wage gap between individuals (25-64 year-olds) with and without upper secondary educational attainment is relatively modest across OECD countries. On average across the OECD, workers without upper secondary qualifications earn on average 17% less than those who have completed upper secondary education, while workers with tertiary attainment earn 54% more than those with upper secondary attainment. In Hungary, the wage gap between workers with and without upper secondary attainment is larger than the OECD average, at 23%. The gap between

those with upper secondary and tertiary attainment is also larger than the OECD average, at 73%. This suggests a generally more dispersed wage distribution by educational attainment in Hungary, which may indicate higher relative returns to education but also a higher level of income inequality compared to the OECD average.

- In most OECD countries, a significant share of adults have low levels of literacy proficiency, defined as at or below Level 1 (on a scale of 0-5) in the OECD Survey of Adult Skills, a product of the OECD Programme for the International Assessment of Adult Competencies (PIAAC). Individuals at this level can only understand very short texts with minimal distracting information. In Hungary, 33% of 25-64 year-olds have literacy skills at or below Level 1, which is above the OECD average of 27%.
- Educational attainment and skills are closely linked, although the strength of this relationship varies across countries. In Hungary, tertiary-educated adults score, on average, 48 points higher in literacy proficiency than those with upper secondary or post-secondary non-tertiary attainment in the Survey of Adult Skills. This gap is wider than the OECD average difference of 34 points.
- Average literacy scores fell between Cycle 1 (2012-15) and Cycle 2 (2023) of the Survey of Adult Skills¹. On average across OECD countries, the fall among adults with tertiary attainment was 9 score points, smaller than the average drop of 19 score points among adults without upper secondary qualifications. In Hungary, average literacy scores for adults with tertiary attainment decreased by 10 points (from 296 to 285), while the score for adults without upper secondary attainment decreased by 24 points (from 219 to 195).
- In Hungary, as in all OECD countries, adults with better literacy skills are more likely to participate in education and training. In 2023, 62% of adults (25–64 year-olds) with high literacy proficiency (i.e. at or above Level 4) in the Survey of Adult Skills participated in formal and/or non-formal education and training in the last year, compared to just 16% of those with proficiency at or below Level 1.

Access to education, participation and progression

- Education systems must adapt to changes in the number of children by expanding or reducing provision accordingly. In many countries, the population of children aged 0-4 changed significantly between 2013 and 2023 and is projected to change further by 2033. Hungary experienced an increase of 1% in the number of 0-4 year-olds, and is projected to see a decline of 5% between 2023 and 2033.
- The share of students in lower secondary education who are at least two years older than the expected age for their grade varies widely across OECD countries, ranging from virtually none in some countries to over 10% in others. In Hungary, the share is at the upper end of the OECD distribution in 2023, at 11%.
- Bachelor's or equivalent programmes are the main entry point into tertiary education in most OECD countries, with an average of 78% of those starting tertiary education for the first time enrolling in such programmes. In Hungary, the share is lower at 73%.
- Women make up the majority of first-time entrants to tertiary education in most OECD countries. In Hungary, they accounted for 54% of first-time entrants in 2023, down from 56% in 2013. Across the OECD, women make up 54% of new entrants on average, the same share as in 2013.
- Across the OECD, the two most popular broad fields of study are science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM) and business, administration, and law, each accounting for 23% of

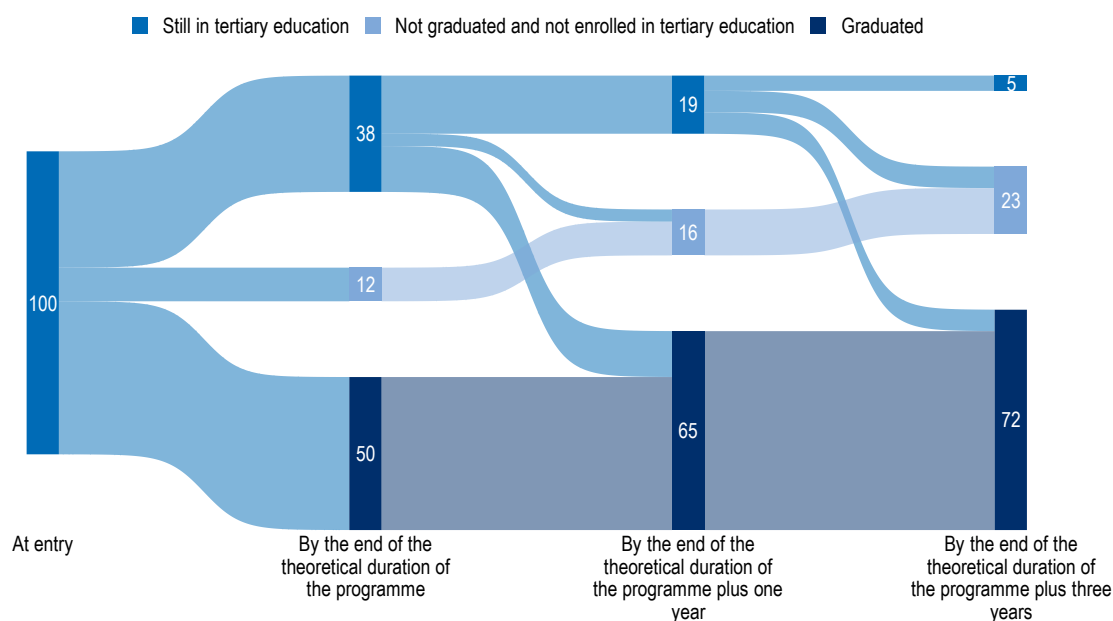
¹ Does not include adults who in Cycle 2 were only administered the doorstep interview due to a language barrier.

graduates from bachelor's or equivalent programmes. They are closely followed by the broad field of arts and humanities, social sciences, journalism and information, at 22% of graduates. In Hungary, 24% of bachelor's degree students graduate from a STEM field, 23% from business, administration and law, and 21% from arts and humanities, social sciences, journalism and information.

- In many countries, it is common for new entrants to bachelor's programmes to take at least one gap year between the end of their upper secondary education and the start of their tertiary education. In Hungary, 31% of new entrants do so, below the OECD average of 44%.
- Completion rates reflect the share of new entrants to bachelor's programmes who successfully obtain a tertiary degree within specified timeframes. These rates remain low in most OECD countries. In Hungary, 50% of new entrants complete their bachelor's degree within the theoretical duration of the programme. This rises to 65% one year after the expected end date, and to 72% three years after. In comparison, the OECD average completion rate is 43% within the theoretical duration, increasing to 59% after an additional year and 70% after three years (Figure 3).

Figure 3. Status of new entrants into bachelor's programmes in Hungary, by timeframe

In per cent



For data, see OECD (2025) *Education at a Glance 2025: OECD Indicators*, <https://doi.org/10.1787/1c0d9c79-en>, Table B5.1.

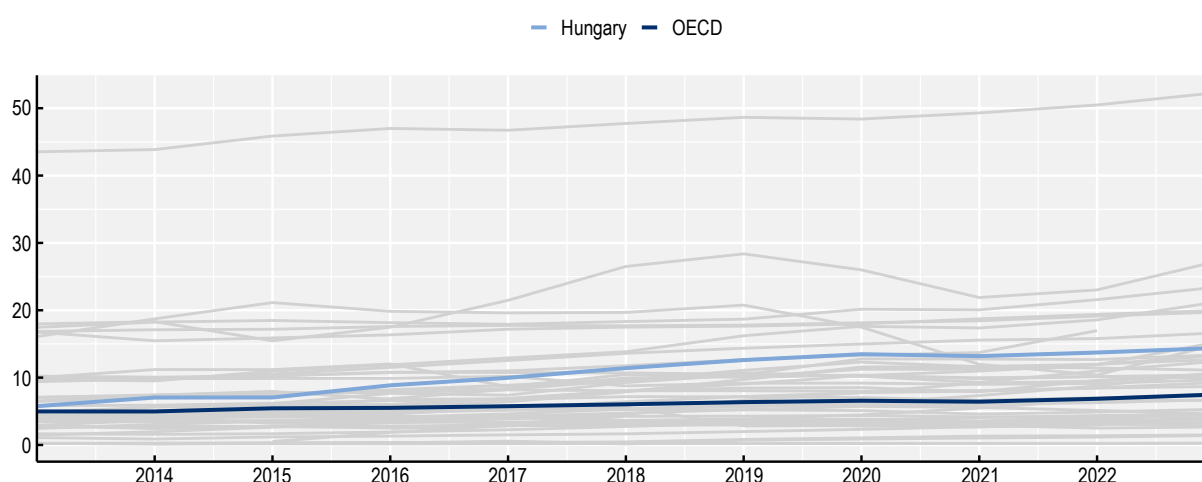
- In all countries, women starting bachelor's programmes are more likely than their male peers to successfully complete their tertiary studies within the three years after the theoretical end of their programme. In Hungary, the gender gap is 15 percentage points (79% for women compared to 64% for men), which is larger than the OECD average of 12 percentage points.
- Completion rates vary by field of study. On average across the OECD, only 58% of new entrants to bachelor's programmes in STEM fields have graduated at that level in the same field within three years after the expected end of their studies. Completion rates in the field of health and welfare

are significantly higher, at 74%. In Hungary, STEM completion rates are 62%, lower than those for health and welfare, at 66%.

- Students who do not complete their tertiary education may drop out at various stages. High dropout rates in the first year can signal a mismatch between student expectations and the content or demands of their programmes, possibly reflecting a lack of career guidance for prospective students or insufficient support for new entrants. In Hungary, the share of first-time entrants in bachelor's programmes who drop out after the first year is lower than the OECD average, at 5% (compared to 13%).
- International student mobility in tertiary education continues to rise across the OECD, with some countries experiencing substantial growth in the share of international students between 2018 and 2023. On average, 7.4% of all tertiary students across the OECD were international or foreign students, compared to 6% in 2018. Hungary saw an increase, with the share rising from 11.4% to 14.4% (Figure 4).

Figure 4. Trends in the share of international or foreign students in tertiary education (2013 to 2023)

In per cent



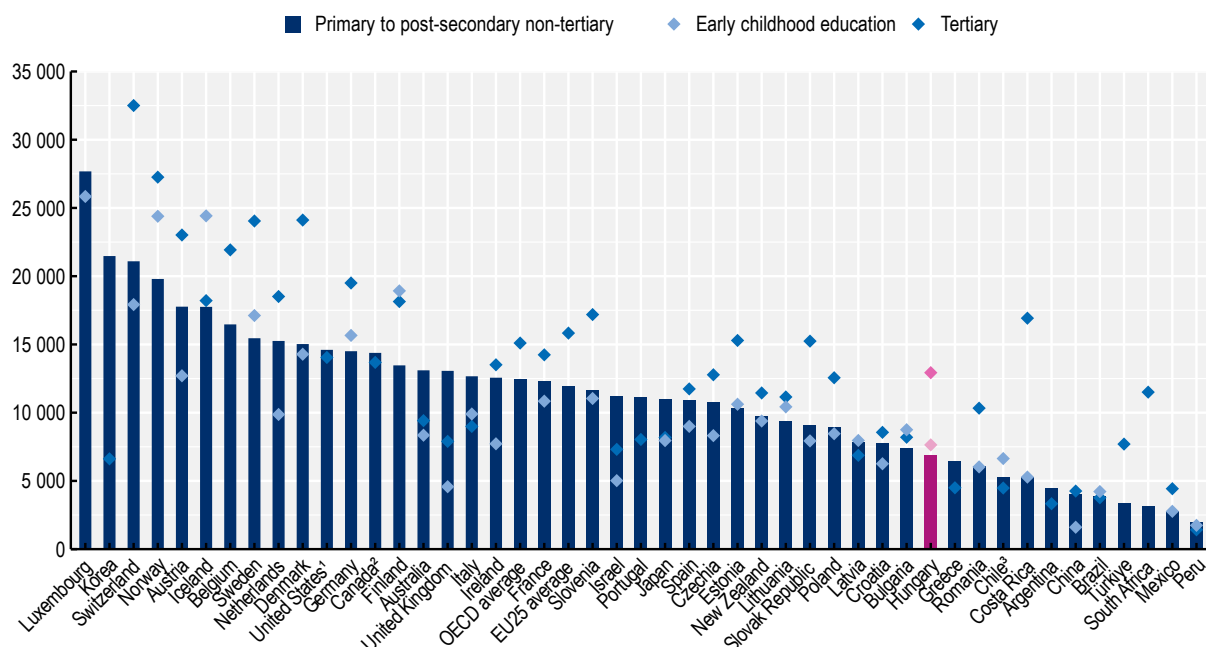
For data, see OECD (2025) *Education at a Glance 2025: OECD Indicators*, <https://doi.org/10.1787/1c0d9c79-en>, Table B4.3.

Financial resources invested in education

- There are significant disparities in how much governments spend each year in education across OECD, partner and accession countries. Hungary spends USD 6 905 per student from primary to post-secondary non-tertiary levels, placing it at the lower end of the country range, which spans from less than USD 2 000 to more than USD 27 000 (Figure 5).

Figure 5. Government expenditure per full-time equivalent student, by level of education (2022)

In equivalent USD converted using PPPs, expenditure on educational institutions



Note: Expenditure at tertiary level includes R&D. Expenditure per student in early childhood education is based on headcounts rather than full-time equivalent students. Expenditure at tertiary level for Luxembourg (USD 54 384) is not shown in the figure.

1. Year of reference differs from 2022.

2. Primary includes pre-primary education.

3. Includes payments by households outside educational institutions.

For data, see OECD (2025) *Education at a Glance 2025: OECD Indicators*, <https://doi.org/10.1787/1c0d9c79-en>, Table C1.1 and Table C1.2.

- As in most other countries, government expenditure in Hungary is higher at tertiary level, including research and development (R&D), than at primary to post-secondary non-tertiary levels. Government expenditure in Hungary amounts to USD 12 931 per tertiary student compared to the OECD average of USD 15 102.
- A large part of the disparity in expenditure per student across OECD, partner and accession countries reflects differences in national income levels. When expenditure is measured as a share of GDP, cross-country differences tend to be smaller, ranging from 2.5% of GDP to 6.9%. In Hungary, education investment in primary to tertiary education stands at 3.4% of GDP, which is below the OECD average of 4.7% by this measure.
- Governments are the primary source of education funding in all OECD countries, especially for the levels covered by compulsory education. In Hungary, governments provide 87.4% of total funding for primary, secondary, and post-secondary non-tertiary education (after transfers to the private sector), which is below the OECD average of 90.4%. At the pre-primary and tertiary levels, private funding often plays a larger role. In Hungary, 90.5% of pre-primary education funding (after transfers) and 63.2% of tertiary education funding (after transfers) come from public sources, compared to OECD averages of 85.6% and 67.4%, respectively.
- Although expenditure per student from primary to tertiary levels increased on average across OECD countries between 2015 and 2022 in real terms (from USD 11 955 to USD 13 210), government spending on education declined in relative terms from 10.9% of public budgets to

10.1%. This suggests the relative priority given to education in overall public spending has fallen across the OECD. In Hungary, expenditure per student increased from USD 7 352 to USD 9 177, while the share devoted to education decreased from 6.7% of public budgets to 5.8% over this period.

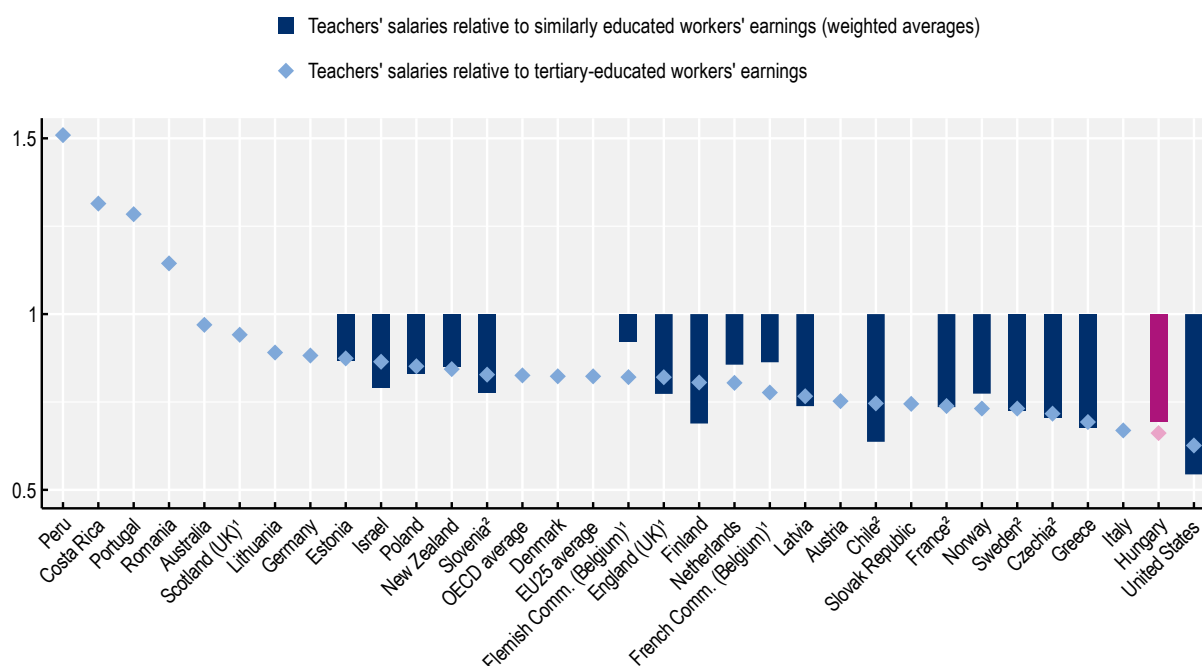
- At pre-primary level, government expenditure in Hungary decreased by 5.7% between 2015 and 2022. This has been accompanied with an increase of 0.2% in the number of children enrolled. As a result, government expenditure per child has decreased, by 5.8%, compared to an average increase of 24% across the OECD since 2015.

Teachers, the learning environment and the organisation of schools

- Attracting second-career teachers can help alleviate teacher shortages while bringing individuals with a broader range of experience into the profession. To support this, 16 out of 28 countries with available data (including Hungary) offer dedicated alternative pathways into teaching for individuals changing careers.
- Competitive salaries can make the teaching profession more attractive, particularly since teachers in many countries earn less than other tertiary-educated workers. In Hungary, the actual salaries of primary teachers are 34% lower than those of tertiary-educated, full-time, full year workers, compared to an average of 17% lower across the OECD. However, increasing teacher salaries can be financially challenging, as staff costs make up the largest share of education expenditure (Figure 6).

Figure 6. Actual salaries of primary teachers relative to earnings of tertiary-educated workers (2024)

Ratio of salaries to the earnings of full-time, full-year workers aged 25-64



Note: Data refer to the ratio of annual average salaries (including bonuses and allowances) of teachers and school heads in public institutions relative to the earnings of workers with similar educational attainment (weighted average) and to the earnings of full-time, full-year workers with tertiary education. Earnings of workers with similar educational attainment to teachers are weighted by the distribution of teachers (or school heads) by qualification level (see Tables X2.10 and X2.11). As values close to one may be difficult to identify in the figure, please refer to the source table.

1. Data on earnings for full-time, full-year workers with tertiary education refer to the whole country.

2. Year of reference for salaries of teachers differs from 2024.

For data, see OECD (2025) *Education at a Glance 2025: OECD Indicators*, <https://doi.org/10.1787/1c0d9c79-en>, Table D3.2.

- Since 2015, actual average salaries of primary teachers have increased in real terms by 14.6% on average across the OECD. In Hungary, they increased by 34.7% in 2024.
- The amount of compulsory instruction time affects teacher salary costs as it influences the number of teachers needed, combined with other factors such as class size and teaching time of teachers. In Hungary, students receive 666 hours of compulsory instruction per year in primary education and 796 hours in lower secondary education. This is below the OECD average of 804 hours in primary and 909 hours in lower secondary education.
- School holidays in primary education last 14.4 weeks per year in Hungary (all breaks combined), compared to 13.5 weeks across the OECD.
- In Hungary, 41% of instruction time in primary education is allocated to mathematics and reading, writing and literature, falling to 24% in lower secondary education. In comparison, the OECD average is for 41% of instruction time in primary education and 27% in lower secondary education to be devoted to these core subjects.
- Countries use a range of admission systems to tertiary public education institutions. These vary as to whether admission is open or selective, and whether applications are submitted directly to institutions or to a central body. In Hungary, admission is selective. Applicants submit their applications to a central body.

More information

For more information on Education at a Glance 2025 and to access the full set of indicators, see: <https://doi.org/10.1787/1c0d9c79-en>.

For more information on the methodology used during the data collection for each indicator, the references to the sources and the specific notes for each country, see Education at a Glance 2025: Sources, Methodologies and Technical Notes, <https://doi.org/10.1787/fcfaf2d1-en>.

For general information on the methodology, please refer to the OECD Handbook for Internationally Comparative Education Statistics 2018, <https://doi.org/10.1787/9789264304444-en>.

Updated data can be found on line at <http://data-explorer.oecd.org/> and by following the StatLinks in the publication.

Explore, compare and visualise more data and analysis using the Education GPS: <https://gpseducation.oecd.org/>.

Questions can be directed to the Education at a Glance team at the OECD Directorate for Education and Skills: EDU.EAG@oecd.org.

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